aircraft as a precision-strike weapon, paving the way for later developments in cruise missiles and combat UAVs.

2.5.4 Experimental combat simulations

First-generation drones also played a role in experimental combat simulations, where militaries tested radio-controlled systems for tactical operations. These early trials explored the feasibility of using drones to simulate enemy aircraft or act as decoys to divert enemy fire. Such experiments highlighted the advantages of deploying unmanned systems in risky scenarios, reducing pilot casualties and improving defense strategies.

2.5.5 Propaganda and research tools

In addition to direct combat training, early drones were used as research and demonstration tools to showcase national technological progress. Governments and military laboratories utilized these aircraft to experiment with remote control technologies, aerodynamics, and radio communications, which later influenced the design of both military UAVs and civilian aircraft.

2.6 Developments and Pioneers of First-generation Drones

The first generation of drones emerged from a period of rapid technological experimentation during the early 20th century, driven by the vision of scientists, engineers, and military strategists who sought to achieve flight without human pilots. This period, extending from World War I through the 1930s, witnessed remarkable progress in radio control, aerodynamics, and propulsion systems. The early innovators and prototype models of this era laid the essential groundwork for all subsequent UAV advancements, transforming the idea of pilotless aircraft from theoretical speculation into practical reality.